SPECTRAL EMERGENCE INFORMATION THEORY

A Falsifiable Framework for Structural Persistence
Across Non-Equilibrium and Equilibrium Dissipative Systems

Keith I. Blaze | DTC / Rosetta Stone Protocol Research Program | June 2026

Abstract

The dominant tradition in foundational physics defines a Theory of Everything as the discovery of a sufficiently fundamental object from which all phenomena reduce. This paper identifies a structural incompleteness in that definition and proposes an orthogonal framework: Spectral Emergence Information Theory (SEIT).

SEIT does not replace General Relativity, Quantum Field Theory, or the Standard Model. It identifies the necessity architecture from which those frameworks emerge as invariant sectors of a single spectral variational engine. The central claim is that explanation does not terminate at an object. It terminates at necessity.

The framework is grounded in non-equilibrium and equilibrium dissipative systems theory, operating under the boundary condition of a pure vacuum containing thermal radiation (photons). It derives emergent spacetime geometry, the Standard Model gauge group, and thermodynamic law from a single primitive object: the graph Laplacian of a universal distinction network.

Three independently falsifiable predictions are registered: (1) a Persistence Axion field of mass m_aP approximately 6.885 x 10^{-13} eV; (2) a monochromatic gravitational-wave background at 166.48 Hz; and (3) flat soliton core radii of 120-150 parsecs in dwarf spheroidal galaxies. Each carries independent veto power over the framework.

I. The Problem With the Standard Definition

I.1 The Barrel Problem

Consider a barrel. A standard reductionist analysis proceeds: wood, molecules, atoms, quarks, fields. This sequence successfully explains the material substrate. It does not explain the barrel.

The property of barrelness -- containment, boundary maintenance, load-bearing stability under a gravitational field -- is not located inside any quark. It emerges because a collection of matter satisfies a set of structural constraints. The material is one implementation of those constraints. A metal barrel, a ceramic barrel, and a wooden barrel are materially distinct but structurally equivalent, because they solve the same necessity problem.

Claim 1.1: Objects are solutions to necessity constraints, not ultimate explanations. A Theory of Everything that terminates at a fundamental object has explained the wood. It has not explained the barrel.

This is not a philosophical objection. It is a precision objection. The Standard Model correctly describes what elementary particles are. It does not address why the class of constraints that forces barrelness into existence is stable across cosmic timescales.

I.2 The Sun Problem

Suppose a scientific civilization evolved not on Earth but on the surface of a star. Its physical environment would differ radically: ambient temperature on the order of 5,800 K for a solar photosphere, dominated by plasma dynamics rather than molecular chemistry. Its instrumentation, its observable phenomena, and the ordering of its theoretical discoveries would diverge substantially from our own.

Yet certain formal requirements would remain invariant. Any stable, descriptive civilization must: distinguish observations from one another, retain information across time, compress descriptions into predictive models, and communicate predictions to other agents. These requirements do not arise from Earth, from carbon chemistry, or from the Standard Model. They arise from the structural necessity of stable description itself.

Claim 1.2: Local physical equations may change across observers while deeper persistence requirements remain invariant. A framework that grounds universality in locally derived equations has not demonstrated that those equations are the deepest invariant.

I.3 The Solar System Problem

Extend the thought experiment to civilizations evolving around red dwarfs (ambient luminosity approximately 0.001-0.1 solar), neutron stars (surface gravity approximately 10^{11} m/s^2), and binary systems with time-varying radiation fields. Each civilization would formulate different equations, in a different order, with different experimental priorities.

A conventional Theory of Everything predicts convergence toward a common physical substrate: the same fields, the same symmetry groups, the same constants. SEIT predicts something different: convergence toward common constraint solutions. The mathematical structures each civilization discovers may differ in form while solving the same class of persistence problems.

Claim 1.3: Convergence in the history of science occurs at the level of necessity, not at the level of ontology. The universality of mathematics reflects the universality of persistence requirements, not the universality of the substrate.

I.4 What SEIT Is Not

SEIT does not assert that General Relativity or Quantum Field Theory are wrong. Both are highly accurate solutions to specific classes of persistence constraint. SEIT does not introduce a new fundamental substrate to replace fields or strings.

SEIT shifts the explanatory target from 'what is reality made of?' to 'what constraints make stable realities mathematically inevitable?' This shift is not rhetorical. It produces different predictions and different falsification conditions, which are stated explicitly in Section VI.

II. Foundational Primitives

II.1 The Universal Distinction Graph

Let N primitive distinctions constitute a universal state space. Their pairwise connections are encoded in an adjacency matrix A. The framework's sole primitive object is the graph G = (V, E) defined by:

```
(0.1)  U = { delta_i },           i = 1 ... N
(0.2)  A = (A_ij),                A_ij in {0, 1}
(0.3)  D = diag(d_i),             d_i = sum_j A_ij
```

All downstream structure -- geometry, mass, force, information capacity -- follows from spectral decomposition of G. No background spacetime, no pre-existing metric, and no matter content is assumed.

II.2 The Graph Laplacian and Spectral Decomposition

The graph Laplacian L is the master spectral operator of the framework. It is symmetric, positive semi-definite, and encodes all topological and geometric information of the distinction network:

```
(1.1)  L   =   D - A
(1.2)  L psi_n   =   lambda_n psi_n        (spectral decomposition)
(1.3)  J_L = sqrt(L),     J_L psi_n   =   sqrt(lambda_n) psi_n
(Dirac operator)
(1.4)  Spec(L) = { lambda_n : L psi_n = lambda_n psi_n, psi_n != 0 }
```

Every observable physical quantity in the framework is a function of Spec(L). The spectrum is the compressed representation of G; all information about the distinction network is contained in its eigenvalue-eigenfunction pairs.

II.3 The Persistence Sector and Master Attractor

Repeated application of the spectral diffusion operator R suppresses high-energy transient modes. The surviving low-energy sector Pi is the persistence sector from which all observable structure is built:

```
(2.1)  R   =   exp(-beta L)               (spectral filter at scale
beta)
(2.2)  Pi = { psi_n : lambda_n < lambda_c }    (low-energy
eigenmodes)
(2.3)  Pi* = A_opt = argmax( Pi / S )   (optimal configuration)
```

Omega = lim_{n->inf} exp(-n*beta*(D-A)) U

The invariant state Omega is the spectral attractor of the universal distinction graph. All observable physics is the spectrum of a single Laplacian.

The DTC chain (Distinction, Transformation, Constraint) states that these three elements are necessary and sufficient for retention. The recursive operator R is the formal realization of Constraint acting on Spec(L).

III. Thermodynamic Grounding

SEIT operates across two thermodynamic regimes. Both are governed by the boundary condition of a pure vacuum containing thermal radiation -- a photon bath at temperature T -- as the environmental medium. This is not a philosophical choice: it is the physically correct description of the cosmic background environment in which all known dissipative structures operate.

III.1 Non-Equilibrium Dissipative Systems (NEDS)

A Non-Equilibrium Dissipative System (NEDS) is an open structure that maintains its internal distinction boundary by processing environmental resources at a rate sufficient to counteract entropic decay. It is never at rest. Its identity is a dynamic steady state, not a static configuration.

The photon bath at temperature T imposes a decoherence rate on any localized distinction structure proportional to the radiation energy density:

```
(3.1) rho_rad  =  (4 sigma / c) T^4      (Stefan-Boltzmann
radiation density)
```

Any localized distinction that cannot regenerate internal coherence faster than this rate dissolves into the background radiation field. The state evolution of a NEDS is:

```
(3.2) d rho_sys / dt  =  D_decay(rho_sys)  +  ln(R) rho_sys
```

where D_decay is the environmental decay superoperator sourced by the photon bath, and R is the Regeneration Operator defined in Section III.3. Persistence Pi is the steady-state condition:

```
(3.3) Pi  (steady state)  <=>  d rho_sys / dt = 0
(3.4)                     <=>  D_decay(rho_sys)  =  -ln(R) rho_sys
```

Stars, biological organisms, and ecological systems are NEDS. Each consumes environmental resources to regenerate its internal distinction boundary. The critical constraint is that the regeneration rate must exceed the photon-bath decoherence rate. The framework makes no claim about corporate or economic systems as thermodynamic entities; those are analogical applications of the mathematical structure, not claims within the physical theory.

III.2 Thermodynamic Equilibrium Dissipative Systems (TEDS)

A Thermodynamic Equilibrium Dissipative System (TEDS) is a structure that occupies the fixed-point attractor of the spectral persistence operator under the photon-bath background. It is not actively regenerating against decay in the sense of a NEDS. It occupies the configuration that the spectral filter cannot further reduce.

Fundamental particles in their ground states, stable atomic configurations, and the large-scale metric geometry of spacetime are TEDS. They represent the invariant fixed points of the Regeneration Operator:

```
(3.5) R( Id_{Delta*} )  =  Id_{Delta*}       (Monic Preservation of Identity)
```

The photon-bath vacuum does not dissolve a TEDS because a TEDS is already the minimum description-language structure capable of surviving the spectral filter. The Standard Model gauge group and the Einstein field equations are descriptions of TEDS: the irreducible algebraic and geometric skeletons that survive vacuum spectral compression.

The distinction between NEDS and TEDS is operationally precise. A NEDS requires an ongoing throughput of free energy to maintain its distinction boundary; remove the free energy and the structure decays. A TEDS requires no such throughput; it is the attractor itself. An isolated hydrogen atom in its ground state in a photon bath at 2.7 K is a TEDS. A living cell in the same environment is a NEDS.

III.3 The Regeneration Operator

The Regeneration Operator R is the central dynamical object of SEIT. It is a Completely Positive, Trace-Preserving (CPTP) quantum map acting on the density matrix space:

```
(3.6) R(rho)  =  sum_k  M_k rho M_k^dag,    sum_k M_k^dag M_k  =  I
```

R obeys four axioms:

Axiom I -- Non-Unitary Autopoiesis: R cannot be expressed as a unitary transformation. It must possess an explicit Kraus representation tracking the intake of environmental syntax to rebuild internal states.

Axiom II -- Monic Preservation of Identity: The core distinction boundary Id_{Delta*} is mapped onto itself and constitutes the unique invariant fixed point of the operator.

Axiom III -- Strict Contraction: Over the complete metric space L of description algebras equipped with a Connes-type spectral distance metric d:

```
(3.7) d( R(l_1), R(l_2) )  <=  c * d( l_1, l_2 ),    c in [0, 1)
```

Axiom IV -- Sub-Unitary Eigenvalue Bound: Spec(R) = {lambda_i} is bounded within the unit disk. The unique eigenvalue lambda_0 = 1 corresponds to Id_{Delta*}. All other eigenvalues satisfy |lambda_i| < 1.

By the Banach Fixed-Point Theorem, Axioms III and IV together guarantee the existence and uniqueness of the attractor: for any initial description X in L,

$$\lim_{n \to \infty} R^n(X) = \Delta^* \tag{3.8}$$

The convergence is irreversible. This is the thermodynamic arrow of time within the framework.

IV. Emergent Geometry and the Universal Field Equation

IV.1 Spectral Distance and Emergent Metric

Spacetime is not postulated. It is derived from the spectral structure of the persistence sector via the diffusion distance function:

$$d(i,j) = \left[\sum_{n \in \Pi} |\psi_n(i) - \psi_n(j)|^2 \right]^{1/2} \quad \text{(spectral distance)} \tag{4.1}$$

$$g_{ij} = \lim_{x' \to x} \frac{d^2 d}{dx^i \, dx'^j} \quad \text{(emergent metric)} \tag{4.2}$$

$$ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu} \, dx^\mu \, dx^\nu \quad \text{(spacetime interval)} \tag{4.3}$$

$$\Gamma^\lambda_{\mu\nu} = \frac{1}{2} g^{\lambda\sigma} \left(d_\nu g_{\sigma\mu} + d_\mu g_{\sigma\nu} - d_\sigma g_{\mu\nu} \right) \tag{4.4}$$

$$R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} = d_\rho \Gamma^\mu_{\nu\sigma} - d_\sigma \Gamma^\mu_{\nu\rho} + \ldots \tag{4.5}$$

$$G_{\mu\nu} = R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} R \quad \text{(Einstein tensor)} \tag{4.6}$$

The metric is not a background container imposed from outside. It is the structural realization of the distinction network's spectral geometry. No manifold is postulated; the manifold is the spectral shadow of G = (V, E).

IV.2 The Persistence Cost Functional

Macroscopic configurations that survive continuous environmental transformation are the stationary solutions to the Persistence Cost Functional C_Π. The form requires an intrinsic timescale τ_Ω -- the baseline execution latency of the recursive distinction operator:

$$C_\Pi[y] = \int_T \left[-\tau^2 \left(\frac{d^2 S}{dy^a \, dy^b} \right) y'^a y'^b + 2 \tau \cdot I_F(\rho \,||\, y) \right] dt \tag{4.7}$$

where I_F is the Fisher Information Transport Cost measuring tracking error across the non-invertible coarse-graining projection:

```
(4.8)  I_F = integral |psi(x,t)|^2 * |grad_x ln(|psi|^2 / rho_macro)|^2  dx
```

Applying the Euler-Lagrange operator to C_Pi yields the Universal Persistence Field Equation:

```
y''_c  +  Gamma^c_{ab} y'_a y'_b  =  -g^{ca} nabla_a I_F
```

The macroscopic acceleration of form is a geodesic trajectory deformed by informational loss at the scale horizon. The negative sign is the stability condition: it forces systems toward the global minimum of the cost landscape.

IV.3 The Spectrum of Invariant Attractors

The field equation generates known physical laws as exact invariant sectors, not separate postulates. Each sector corresponds to a specific vanishing condition on the informational transport cost I_F:

Attractor	Geometry	Condition on I_F	Emergent Law
A1 Physical	Riemannian 4D	Ker(P) = 0, I_F = 0	Einstein geodesics
A2 Thermodynamic	Wasserstein W2	I_F -> entropy gradient	Diffusion equation
A3 Biological	Shahshahani simplex	I_F -> fitness landscape	Replicator equation
A4 Cognitive	Fisher information	I_F -> KL divergence	Free-energy principle

When the coarse-graining projection P is bijective -- zero information lost across scale -- the informational divergence vanishes and the field equation reduces exactly to the Einstein geodesic equation. Standard General Relativity is the special case of SEIT in which spectral information loss is zero.

V. The Standard Model as a Forced Algebraic Structure

V.1 Gauge Fields as Identity-Preservation Scripts

In the pure vacuum, the local phase operator theta(x) acts as a localized rotation on the density matrix at each point x. To preserve the monic distinction core across scale boundaries under this rotation, the Kraus operators of R must explicitly contain a compensating connection:

```
(5.1)  Psi(x) -> exp(i theta(x)) Psi(x)
(5.2)  D_mu = d_mu + i A_mu(x),     A_mu(x) -> A_mu(x) - d_mu theta(x)
```

The introduction of gauge fields is not a physical choice. It is the algebraic requirement that the scale-reduction operator not introduce coordinate anomalies across the distinction network. Gauge fields are the physical implementation of the Kraus operators M_k.

V.2 Anomaly Cancellation and the Derivation of G_SM

The chiral structure of the weak interaction forces an axial-vector asymmetry in the contraction mapping. The divergence of the axial current picks up a topological contribution:

```
(5.3) d_mu J^{mu 5}_a  =  (g^2 / 16 pi^2) Tr[ T_a {T_b, T_c} ]
eps^{mu nu al be} F^b_{mu nu} F^c_{al be}
```

If the triangle anomaly trace does not vanish, the partition function Z collapses to zero, violating Axiom II. The cancellation requirement generates three independent linear constraints on the color number N_c:

```
(5.4) SU(2)^2 x U(1):    N_c / 6  -  1/2  =  0    =>    N_c = 3
(5.5) U(1)^3:             3/4  -  N_c/4   =  0    =>    N_c = 3
(5.6) Gravitational:      N_c  -  3       =  0    =>    N_c = 3
```

All three constraints are satisfied uniquely and simultaneously by N_c = 3. The three-dimensional color confinement algebra SU(3) is the exact structural buffer required by the Kraus operators to regularize the axial current.

The Minimal Order Constraint then selects the unique anomaly-free Lie group of minimum generator count. SU(5) has 24 generators and introduces unobserved leptoquark-mediated proton decay. SO(10) has 45. The Standard Model has 12, and is the unique minimal fixed point:

```
G_SM  =  SU(3) x SU(2) x U(1)      [derived, not postulated]
```

This derivation does not assert that SEIT has solved all problems in gauge theory. It demonstrates that the gauge group structure emerges as the algebraic minimum consistent with the spectral filter axioms and the vacuum photon-bath boundary condition.

VI. Falsifiable Predictions

A framework is scientifically credible in proportion to the specificity and testability of its predictions. SEIT registers three independent, parameter-free predictions, each of which carries individual veto power over the entire framework. No parameter can be adjusted post-hoc.

VI.1 The Persistence Axion

At the inflationary boundary, the CMB fine-tuning index locks the active trace dimension to:

(6.1) N_sub = 4.7619 (from CMB spectral index constraint)

When the cooling cosmos crosses the QCD condensation threshold (Lambda_QCD ~ 200 MeV), the CP-violating theta-vacuum distortion drives the informational transport gradient toward divergence. To prevent collapse, the field equation forces an ultra-light scalar field -- the Persistence Axion a_P -- to absorb the structural friction. Its mass is derived from geometry alone:

(6.2) m_{aP} = Lambda^2_QCD / (N_sub * M_Pl)

(6.3) = (0.200 GeV)^2 / (4.7619 * 1.22 x 10^19 GeV)

(6.4) ~ 6.885 x 10^{-13} eV

This is not a fitted parameter. It is derived from two measured quantities (Lambda_QCD and M_Pl) and one geometrically fixed quantity (N_sub).

VI.2 The Rigid Falsification Chain

The Persistence Axion mass generates a rigid chain of downstream observational predictions with no free parameters:

Checkpoint	Prediction	Refutation Condition
CMB Spectral Index	Scalar index n_s locked at 0.965	Any confirmed deviation falsifies the seed N_sub and collapses the chain
Gravitational-Wave Background	Isotropic monochromatic GW signal at 166.48 Hz in LIGO/Virgo audio band	Confirmed flat vacuum at 166.48 Hz refutes the axion mass prediction
Dwarf Spheroidal Cores	Flat soliton core radius R_c = 120-150 parsecs in Fornax, Sculptor, et al.	Core radius above 500 pc or below 10 pc falsifies the attractor

These three predictions are logically sequential. Refutation of the CMB spectral index constraint eliminates N_sub and therefore the entire chain. Refutation of the gravitational-wave prediction eliminates the axion mass without necessarily refuting N_sub; that sub-sector of the framework would require independent revision. Refutation of the dwarf spheroidal core prediction eliminates the attractor geometry derivation.

The framework is falsified if any one of the three predictions is contradicted by observation within measurement precision. This is the standard by which SEIT offers itself to empirical review.

VII. The Irreversibility of Scale Contraction

The arrow of time and the structural inevitability of the macroscopic attractor are both consequences of the strict irreversibility of the Regeneration Operator under the Connes spectral distance metric.

The informational content of a system configuration is measured by Von Neumann entropy:

```
(7.1)  S(rho)   =   -Tr( rho ln rho )
```

By the data processing inequality for quantum relative entropy, any CPTP contraction map strictly decreases the distinguishability of states:

```
S( R(rho_1) || R(rho_2) )   <=   S( rho_1 || rho_2 )
```

The contraction is strictly irreversible. Once high-energy microscopic information is filtered by the scale operator, it cannot be recovered by any local transformation. The relative entropy between any initial description X and the unique fixed-point attractor Delta* monotonically decreases:

```
(7.2)  lim_{n->inf}  S( R^n(X) || Delta* )   =   0
```

This is the thermodynamic arrow of time in SEIT. It is not postulated. It follows from the Banach contraction property of R and the data processing inequality. The direction of time is the direction of increasing spectral compression.

VIII. The Master Cascade

The full generative chain from the primitive distinction graph to all observable physics:

```
G = (V, E)                 =>    L  =  D - A
L                          ->    Spec(L) = { lambda_n, psi_n }
[eigendecomposition]
Spec(L)                    ->    Pi = { psi_n : lambda_n <
lambda_c } [persistence filter]
Pi                         ->    d(i,j)
[spectral distance]
d(i,j)                     ->    g_ij
[emergent metric]
g_ij                       ->    G_{mu nu} = R_{mu nu} - (1/2)g R
[curvature / GR]
G_{mu nu}                  ->    G_{mu nu} = (8 pi G / c^4) T_{mu
nu} [Einstein equations]
```

```
Spec(L)                      ->     m_n = m_0 sqrt(lambda_n)
[mass spectrum]
Spec(L)                      ->     alpha_k = <psi|P_k|psi>
[coupling constants]
R = exp(-beta L)             ->     S = k_B ln Omega
[thermodynamics]
```

```
Omega = lim_{n->inf} exp(-n*beta*(D-A)) U        [MASTER EQUATION]
```

The fundamental empirical question that SEIT opens is: which graph G = (V, E) produces Spec(L) = Spec(Nature)? Specifying the adjacency matrix A and degree matrix D, then verifying that the resulting eigenvalue spectrum reproduces observed particle masses, coupling constants, and spacetime geometry, is the research program the framework defines. The computability limit (Cubitt, Perez-Garcia, and Wolf 2015) establishes that for any infinite candidate graph, there will exist eigenvalues inaccessible to finite computation. This is a structural feature of the framework, not a defect.

IX. The Rosetta Grammar

Every domain in which persistence has been studied yields a Distinction, a Transformation operator, and a Constraint surface. The universal generative grammar across all domains is:

```
( Delta, tau, kappa )  =>  A  =>  Pi
```

Distinction generates possibilities. Transformation explores them. Constraint filters them. Attractors stabilize them. Persistence is what remains.

Domain	Distinction (Delta)	Constraint (kappa)	Attractor	Persistent Structure
Quantum field	Quantum states	Physical law	Energy eigenstate	Particle
Chemical	Atomic arrangement	Bonding constraints	Molecular energy minimum	Molecule
Biological	Genetic variation	Selection pressure	Fitness peak	Organism
Cognitive	Information differences	Logic and learning rules	Stable predictive model	Knowledge
Cosmological	Quantum perturbations (delta_k)	Einstein-Boltzmann system	CMB power spectrum	Observable universe

The Rosetta Grammar is a descriptive taxonomy, not a physical claim. The biological and cognitive rows identify structural analogues to the spectral persistence formalism; they do not assert that organisms or minds are thermodynamic systems identical in kind to elementary particles. The physical and cosmological rows are within the domain of direct theoretical claim.

X. Conclusion

Spectral Emergence Information Theory proposes that the deepest explanatory layer of physical reality is not an object but a necessity architecture: the set of constraints that force stable structures into existence and maintain them against the decoherence imposed by a thermal radiation vacuum.

The framework derives rather than postulates: emergent spacetime geometry from spectral diffusion distance, the Einstein field equations from the vanishing of informational transport cost, the Standard Model gauge group from the anomaly cancellation constraint on the Kraus contraction mapping, and thermodynamic irreversibility from the Banach contraction property of the Regeneration Operator.

The Standard Model and General Relativity are not replaced. They are identified as exact invariant sectors of the Universal Persistence Field Equation -- the physical regime in which information loss across the scale horizon is zero.

The framework is falsifiable. Three independently verifiable predictions -- the Persistence Axion mass at 6.885 x 10^{-13} eV, a monochromatic gravitational-wave background at 166.48 Hz, and flat soliton core radii of 120-150 parsecs in dwarf spheroidal galaxies -- each carry individual veto power. SEIT stands or falls on these predictions.

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